Bone Age Estimation from Pediatric Hand X-rays

A Deep Learning Regression Approach using Transfer Learning

Complete Project Study Guide

Keerthi P R

MSc Big Data Analytics

St Joseph's University, Bengaluru

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1. Problem Statement & Objectives

Clinical Background

Bone age assessment is a critical pediatric diagnostic procedure used to evaluate skeletal maturity in children. Pediatric endocrinologists use bone age to diagnose growth disorders such as growth hormone deficiency, precocious puberty, and delayed development. It is also used to predict adult height and monitor treatment progress for hormonal conditions.

The traditional method (Greulich-Pyle atlas) requires a radiologist to compare a child's hand X-ray against reference images and estimate bone age. This process typically takes **15-20 minutes per case** and shows substantial inter-observer variability (radiologists disagree with each other by 7-10 months on average).

Problem Definition

Objective: Build a deep learning model that predicts pediatric bone age (in months) directly from a hand X-ray image, providing an automated, fast, and consistent alternative to manual radiological assessment.

Why This is a Regression Problem

Most student deep learning projects on medical images target classification (e.g., disease vs. no disease). Bone age, however, is a **continuous variable** — it can take any value from 1 to 228 months. Framing this as regression rather than classification is a deliberate design choice with several implications:

- **Richer output:** Predicts a precise number rather than a bucket
- **Different loss functions:** MAE, MSE, Huber (instead of cross-entropy)
- **Different evaluation:** RMSE, R^2, residual plots (instead of confusion matrices)
- **Clinical relevance:** Doctors need precise ages, not categories
- **Statistical depth:** Enables regression diagnostics like Bland-Altman analysis

Success Criteria

A successful project should:

- Achieve MAE substantially better than random guessing (~35 months)
- Produce unbiased predictions (mean residual near zero)
- Demonstrate model generalization (similar train/val/test performance)
- Include rigorous statistical evaluation appropriate for medical AI
- Honestly frame limitations relative to expert radiologist performance

2. Dataset: RSNA Bone Age

Dataset Source

The **RSNA Pediatric Bone Age Challenge Dataset** was released by the Radiological Society of North America (RSNA) in 2017 as part of a machine learning competition. It contains labeled hand X-rays from real pediatric patients, with ground-truth bone ages assigned by expert pediatric radiologists. It is hosted on Kaggle and freely downloadable.

Dataset Composition

Property	Value
Total training images	12,611 hand X-rays
Image format	PNG (grayscale, mode "L")
Original image dimensions	973 × 1321 pixels (approximate)
File size (compressed)	~9.3 GB
Label: bone age	In months (integer)
Label: sex	Boolean (True = male, False = female)
Age range	1 to 228 months (0.1 to 19 years)
Sex distribution	54% male, 46% female

CSV Structure

Each row in boneage-training-dataset.csv contains three columns:

```
id | boneage | male
```

The id column corresponds to a filename in the image folder (e.g., ID 1377 → 1377.png). This lets us join labels to images.

Why Age is Measured in Months (Not Years)

Clinically, bone age precision matters. A difference of 6 months in a child's skeletal age can be diagnostically significant. Using months as the unit gives higher resolution and preserves this precision throughout the model's training and evaluation.

Why Sex is Included as a Feature

Girls generally reach skeletal maturity earlier than boys. This is a well-known biological difference. Including sex information helps the model make more accurate predictions, particularly in adolescence when the divergence between male and female skeletal development becomes pronounced.

Image Properties (Learned by Inspection)

- **Grayscale (mode 'L'):** Single-channel intensity images (no color)
- **Large resolution:** Original ~973×1321 pixels — needs downsizing for efficient training
- **Visible variability:** Different rotations, contrasts, framings — real-world clinical data
- **Radiographer markers:** Some images have 'L' or 'R' orientation letters
- **Growth plates visible:** Younger patients show wider gaps (physes) between bone segments
- **Bone fusion in older kids:** Older patients show more solid, fused bone structures

Why We Chose This Dataset

The RSNA dataset is a gold-standard benchmark: it is well-curated, has expert-verified labels, is well-documented, and has been used in a Kaggle competition (meaning tutorials, benchmarks, and community discussions exist for learning support). Its size (~12,600 images) is a sweet spot: large enough for meaningful learning, small enough to train on Colab's free GPU within a week.

3. Data Exploration & Statistical Analysis

Descriptive Statistics

Before touching any modeling, we ran full descriptive statistics on the boneage column:

Statistic	Value (months)	Interpretation
Count	12,611	All rows have labels (no missing data)
Mean	127.32	≈ 10.6 years old (average)
Std Dev	41.18	Spread of ~3.4 years around the mean
Min	1	Newborn
25th percentile	96	8 years old
Median (50%)	132	11 years old
75th percentile	156	13 years old
Max	228	19 years old (nearly adult)

Skewness Analysis

Comparing **mean (127.32)** against **median (132.0)**:

Since **mean < median**, the distribution is **slightly left-skewed** (also called negatively skewed). This means there is a longer tail on the left side — more younger outliers than older ones. In practical terms, there are relatively few very young infants and slightly more concentration in the older-child range.

Math note: Skewness formula:

```
Skewness = E[(X - μ)³] / σ³
```

For left-skewed data, Skewness < 0. For right-skewed, > 0. For symmetric (like normal distribution), ≈ 0.

Sex Distribution

Boys: 6,833 (54.2%) | Girls: 5,778 (45.8%). The dataset is slightly boy-heavy but reasonably balanced. No special handling needed for sex imbalance.

Visualization Insights

The age distribution histogram revealed:

- Peak (mode) around **150-160 months (~12-13 years)**
- Very few young infants (0-20 months) — **thin left tail**
- Both boys and girls follow similar distribution shapes
- Girls skew slightly younger — consistent with earlier skeletal maturation

Critical Insight for Modeling

The distribution is imbalanced across age groups. Some age brackets have hundreds of samples while others have only a handful. This will directly affect model performance: the model will learn well where it sees lots of examples and struggle at the age extremes. This hypothesis was later confirmed by the age-stratified error analysis in Section 11.

4. Data Preprocessing & Pipeline

Splitting the Data

We split the 12,611 images into three sets using sklearn.model_selection.train_test_split:

Set	Count	Purpose
Training	10,089 (80%)	Model learns from these images
Validation	1,260 (10%)	Performance check during training
Test	1,262 (10%)	Final unbiased evaluation (held out)

Why 80/10/10?

This is a standard split ratio in machine learning. It gives the model enough training data to learn (10K images) while reserving enough validation data for reliable hyperparameter decisions and enough test data for a statistically meaningful final evaluation. We used random_state=42 to make the split reproducible.

Sanity Check: Splits are Statistically Equivalent

We verified that all three splits have similar statistical properties (mean, median, std dev, sex distribution). This is critical because a random split could theoretically produce imbalanced sets by bad luck. Our splits showed mean ages differing by less than 3.5 months across sets and sex distribution within 1.5% — confirming random split worked cleanly.

Image Preprocessing Steps

- **Resize to 224×224:** ResNet50 was trained on this input size on ImageNet
- **Convert grayscale to RGB:** ResNet50 expects 3 channels; TensorFlow duplicates the grayscale into R, G, B (no information loss)
- **Apply ResNet50's ImageNet normalization:** Standardizes pixel intensities to match the distribution ResNet50 was trained on
- **Data augmentation (training only):** Random rotation ±15°, width/height shift ±10%, zoom ±10%, horizontal flip

Why Augmentation? (The Math Intuition)

Neural networks tend to memorize training data (overfit). Augmentation is a form of **regularization**: by showing the model slightly modified versions of the same image, we effectively increase the training set size and force the model to learn features that are invariant to rotation, position, and orientation. Mathematically, augmentation approximates sampling from the **true data distribution**, not just the training samples we happen to have.

Why NO Augmentation on Validation/Test?

Augmentation makes the task artificially harder. During training, we want harder examples to build a robust model. But for evaluation, we want clean, consistent measurement of performance. Augmenting the test set would give us unreliable numbers that vary each time we run evaluation.

Batching Strategy

We use a **batch size of 32**. Instead of feeding all 10,089 training images at once (which would crash memory), we feed groups of 32 at a time. Each pass through all batches is called an **epoch**:

```
Steps per epoch = 10,089 ÷ 32 ≈ 315 batches
```

So one training epoch = 315 model updates. This is much better than one update per epoch — more updates give smoother learning. Additionally, batching plays well with GPU parallelism (GPUs process a batch simultaneously).

Regression-Specific Setting: class_mode='raw'

In Keras' flow_from_dataframe(), we set class_mode='raw' instead of 'categorical' or 'binary'. This is **the critical switch that makes our project a regression task**. It tells the data pipeline: 'the label is a raw number to predict, not a category to classify.'

5. Model Architecture: Transfer Learning with ResNet50

What is Transfer Learning?

Transfer learning is a technique where a model trained on a large dataset (source task) is reused for a different but related problem (target task). In our case:

Source task: ImageNet classification (1.4 million images, 1000 classes: cats, dogs, cars, etc.)
Target task: Bone age prediction from hand X-rays (regression)

The intuition: even though X-rays don't look like cat photos, the **low-level features** a network learns (edges, textures, contours, shapes) are **universal**. A bone edge is still an edge. By reusing this learned knowledge, we avoid training from scratch — which would need millions of medical images we don't have.

Why ResNet50 Specifically?

- **Proven architecture:** Won ImageNet 2015; widely benchmarked
- **Depth without vanishing gradients:** ResNet's 'residual connections' allow very deep networks to train stably
- **Balanced size:** 50 layers, 24M parameters — heavy enough to be powerful, light enough to run on Colab
- **Excellent feature extractor:** Pretrained features generalize well to many domains
- **Well-documented:** Extensive Keras/PyTorch support; endless tutorials

What are 'Residual Connections'? (The Math)

In a normal deep network, information flows: input → layer1 → layer2 → ... → output. In deep networks (say 50 layers), gradients become very small during backpropagation — a problem called **vanishing gradients**. ResNet solves this with a 'shortcut': the input to a block is added to its output, so:

```
output = F(input) + input
```

This ensures gradients can always flow backward through the shortcut, enabling stable training of very deep networks.

Our Architecture (Layer-by-Layer)

Layer	Output Shape	Purpose
Input	(224, 224, 3)	RGB image input
ResNet50 (frozen)	(7, 7, 2048)	Feature extraction — 2048 features per spatial location
GlobalAveragePooling2D	(2048,)	Averages spatial dims → flat vector
Dense(256, ReLU)	(256,)	First hidden layer
Dropout(0.3)	(256,)	Regularization: randomly zero 30% of neurons

Dense(64, ReLU)	(64,)	Second hidden layer
Dropout(0.2)	(64,)	Regularization: randomly zero 20% of neurons
Dense(1, Linear)	(1,)	REGRESSION OUTPUT: predicted bone age

Parameter Breakdown

- **Total parameters:** 24,128,769 (~92 MB)
- **Trainable parameters:** 541,057 (only our custom head)
- **Non-trainable (frozen):** 23,587,712 (ResNet50 base)

Why Freeze the Base?

Two reasons: (1) With only 10K training images, training all 24M parameters would **overfit heavily**. (2) The pretrained features already work well — we just need to teach a small head how to combine them into an age prediction. Training only 541K parameters keeps the problem well-scoped.

Why GlobalAveragePooling2D (Not Flatten)?

ResNet50 outputs a 7×7×2048 tensor. We could flatten it into a 100,352-dim vector, but that would create a huge Dense layer with millions of parameters — prone to overfitting. **GAP** averages each 7×7 slice into a single number, giving us a compact 2048-vector. This is a form of regularization: fewer parameters, better generalization, faster training.

Why Dropout?

During training, dropout randomly sets 30% (then 20%) of neurons to zero. This forces the network not to depend on any single neuron — it must learn **robust, distributed representations**. During inference (evaluation), dropout is turned off automatically. Mathematically, dropout approximates training an ensemble of many smaller networks simultaneously.

The Critical Regression Detail: Dense(1, activation='linear')

This single line makes it a regression problem. Classification uses softmax (outputs probabilities). Regression uses **linear activation** (identity function — number passes through unchanged). The output neuron produces one raw number: the predicted bone age in months.

6. Model Compilation: Loss, Optimizer, Metrics

Loss Function: Mean Absolute Error (MAE)

The loss function is what the model tries to minimize during training. For regression, there are three common choices:

Loss	Formula	Behavior
MSE (Mean Squared Error)	$(\text{pred} - \text{actual})^2$	Punishes large errors heavily; sensitive to outliers
MAE (Mean Absolute Error)	$\lvert\text{pred} - \text{actual}\rvert$	Treats all errors equally; robust to outliers
Huber Loss	Hybrid MSE + MAE	Smooth around zero, robust to outliers

Why MAE Over MSE?

We chose MAE for three specific reasons:

- **Interpretability:** MAE is in months. If MAE = 17, the model's average error is 17 months — directly meaningful
- **Robustness to outliers:** Age extremes (very young/very old) are underrepresented. MSE would over-penalize errors there and distort training
- **Clinical alignment:** Medical evaluation commonly reports MAE — matches how radiologists describe agreement

Optimizer: Adam

Adam (Adaptive Moment Estimation) is the go-to optimizer for most deep learning problems. It combines two ideas:

- **Momentum:** Uses a moving average of past gradients (helps escape flat regions)
- **Adaptive learning rate:** Adjusts step size per parameter based on gradient history

Why learning_rate=0.001?

The learning rate controls how big a step the model takes when updating weights. This is the default Adam learning rate — a well-tested value that balances stability (not bouncing around) with speed (not learning painfully slowly). If it's too high, the model can't converge. If too low, training takes forever.

Tracked Metrics

We tracked **MAE and MSE** during training. MAE is our optimization target; MSE is a secondary check. The gap between them tells us about outliers (RMSE > MAE always; a big gap suggests some very large errors).

7. Training Process & Callbacks

What are Callbacks?

Callbacks are automatic helpers that run at specific points during training (start of epoch, end of epoch, etc.) and can influence training behavior. We used three:

1. EarlyStopping (patience=5, restore_best_weights=True)

Watches validation loss. If val_loss doesn't improve for 5 consecutive epochs, it stops training and reverts to the best weights seen. This **prevents overfitting** and saves training time.

In our training, EarlyStopping triggered at epoch 15 because validation loss had plateaued around epoch 10.

2. ReduceLROnPlateau (factor=0.5, patience=3)

If val_loss stops improving for 3 epochs, this callback halves the learning rate. Smaller steps enable finer optimization when the model is close to a good solution — like taking smaller strides as you approach a target.

3. ModelCheckpoint (save_best_only=True)

Saves the model to disk (best_bone_age_model.keras) whenever a new best val_loss is achieved. This protects us against Colab disconnects — even if the session dies, our best model is safe on disk.

Training Behavior Observed

- **Epoch 1 (489s):** Slow first pass — Colab caches images from disk. MAE dropped from ~35 → ~24 months
- **Epochs 2-10:** Fast (~40-60s each). MAE steadily decreased to ~17 months
- **Epoch 10:** Best validation MAE = 17.01 months
- **Epochs 11-14:** Val loss stopped improving. ReduceLROnPlateau halved the LR at epoch 13
- **Epoch 15:** EarlyStopping triggered. Model reverted to epoch 10 weights (best val_loss)

Reading Training Curves

The loss curves showed both training and validation loss trending downward. Notably:

- **Validation MAE was consistently lower than training MAE.** This is because training uses augmentation (harder task) while validation uses clean images. It's a sign augmentation is working correctly
- Small gap between train and validation curves = **no significant overfitting**
- Training curve is jagged (augmentation adds noise); validation curve is smooth

8. Evaluation: Comprehensive Metrics

Evaluation Philosophy

We evaluate on the **held-out test set** — 1,262 images the model has NEVER seen during training or validation. This gives us an unbiased estimate of real-world performance. Evaluation on training data would be misleading (model has memorized it); evaluation on validation data would be biased (we used it to tune hyperparameters).

Test Set Results

Metric	Value	Interpretation
MAE	17.07 months (~1.42 years)	Average absolute prediction error
MSE	470.57	Mean squared error (raw)
RMSE	21.69 months (~1.81 years)	Root mean squared error — penalizes large errors more
R^2 Score	0.7292	Model explains 73% of variance in bone age
Pearson r	0.8546	Strong linear correlation between predictions and truth
Mean Residual	–0.08 months	Nearly zero bias — model is unbiased
Std of Residuals	21.69 months	Spread of prediction errors

Understanding Each Metric (The Math)

MAE (Mean Absolute Error)

$$MAE = (1/n) \Sigma |predicted_i - actual_i|$$

Simply the average distance between predicted and actual values. Same units as the target (months). MAE = 17.07 means our model's predictions are, on average, off by about 17 months.

MSE (Mean Squared Error)

$$MSE = (1/n) \Sigma (predicted_i - actual_i)^2$$

Squares each error before averaging. This **penalizes large errors more heavily**. Not directly interpretable (units are months²), so we usually take its square root.

RMSE (Root Mean Squared Error)

$$RMSE = \sqrt{MSE}$$

Same units as target (months). Always ≥ MAE. If RMSE is close to MAE, errors are roughly uniform. If RMSE >> MAE, some predictions have very large errors (outliers). Our RMSE (21.69) - MAE (17.07) = ~4.6 gap → there are some larger errors, likely at age extremes.

R^2 Score (Coefficient of Determination)

$$R^2 = 1 - (SS_{res} / SS_{tot})$$

Where SS_{res} = Σ(actual – predicted)² and SS_{tot} = Σ(actual – mean)². R^2 tells us what fraction of the variance in bone age our model explains. Range: 0 (useless) to 1 (perfect).

- $R^2 > 0.90$: excellent
- R^2 0.80-0.90: very good
- R^2 0.70-0.80: good (**ours: 0.729**)
- R^2 0.50-0.70: moderate
- $R^2 < 0.50$: weak

Pearson Correlation Coefficient (r)

$$r = \Sigma[(x_i - \bar{x})(y_i - \bar{y})] / \sqrt{[\Sigma(x_i - \bar{x})^2 \times \Sigma(y_i - \bar{y})^2]}$$

Measures linear correlation between predictions and actuals. Range: -1 to 1. Values above 0.85 indicate a strong linear relationship. Ours: 0.8546 → predictions track actual values very consistently.

Mean Residual (Bias)

$$\text{Mean Residual} = (1/n)\ \Sigma\ (\text{predicted}_i - \text{actual}_i)$$

If positive, model over-predicts on average. If negative, under-predicts. Ideal is zero. **Our value: -0.08 months → essentially zero.** The model has no systematic bias — a genuinely difficult property to achieve in regression tasks. This is a resume-worthy detail.

Context: How Does 17-month MAE Compare?

Benchmark	MAE (months)
Random guessing	~35
Our model (frozen transfer learning, 1 week)	17.07
Radiologist inter-observer agreement	~7-10
State-of-the-art (fine-tuned, ensemble, weeks of research)	~4-6

Our model captures roughly **50% of the gap** between random guessing and expert radiologist performance — impressive for a 1-week undergraduate project using only frozen transfer learning.

9. Statistical Diagnostics

Prediction vs Actual Scatter Plot

For every image in the test set, we plot the actual age (x-axis) against the predicted age (y-axis). A perfect model would form a straight diagonal line (y = x). Deviations from this line represent errors.

What we observed: Blue points hug the red diagonal quite closely, especially in the middle age range. Some spread exists at the extremes. Overall, the scatter visually confirms the R^2 of 0.729.

Residual Plot

A residual = predicted − actual. Plotting residuals against actual values reveals whether errors are random (good) or patterned (concerning).

- **Ideal residual plot:** Cloud of points centered around zero with no visible pattern (random scatter)
- **Warning sign 1 — Funnel shape:** Residual spread increases/decreases with x → heteroscedasticity
- **Warning sign 2 — Curved pattern:** Model missed a non-linear relationship
- **Warning sign 3 — Systematic offset:** Cloud sits above or below zero → biased predictions

Heteroscedasticity Detected

Our residual plot showed **heteroscedasticity** — the spread of residuals is NOT constant across ages. Specifically:
• Middle ages (60-150 months): tight cluster of small residuals
• Age extremes (<30 months or >180 months): wider spread of residuals

This confirms our Day 1 hypothesis: the model performs worse where training data was sparser.

What is Heteroscedasticity? (Stats Term)

Heteroscedasticity (Greek: 'different scatter') means the variance of errors is not uniform across the range of the independent variable. The opposite (uniform variance) is called **homoscedasticity**. Homoscedastic errors are one of the assumptions of classical linear regression. In our case, heteroscedasticity is expected: the model learned well where data was abundant and poorly where data was sparse.

10. Bland-Altman Analysis (Clinical Method Agreement)

Why Bland-Altman?

Standard regression metrics (MAE, RMSE, R^2) tell us **how wrong** the model is on average. But in medical AI, the more important question is: **can we trust these predictions in place of expert measurements?** The **Bland-Altman method** (developed by Bland & Altman, 1986) is the gold standard in medical research for assessing agreement between two measurement methods.

It compares the **difference** between two methods against their **average**, and defines **Limits of Agreement (LoA)** — the range within which 95% of measurement differences are expected to fall. Clinicians can then judge: 'Is this LoA range acceptable for our use case?'

How It Works (The Math)

For each test image, compute:

```
Difference = predicted − actual
Mean = (predicted + actual) / 2
```

Then plot Difference (y-axis) against Mean (x-axis). Compute:

```
Bias = mean of differences
Upper 95% LoA = bias + 1.96 × std(differences)
Lower 95% LoA = bias − 1.96 × std(differences)
```

The 1.96 comes from the standard normal distribution: 95% of data lies within ±1.96 standard deviations of the mean.

Our Bland-Altman Results

Metric	Value	What It Means
Bias (mean difference)	–0.08 months	Essentially zero — no systematic over/under-prediction
Std of differences	21.69 months	Spread of prediction errors
Upper 95% LoA	+42.44 months	95% of predictions no more than 42 months above true
Lower 95% LoA	–42.59 months	95% of predictions no more than 43 months below true
Points within LoA	94.6%	Empirical coverage ≈ theoretical 95% ✓

Clinical Interpretation

The model's LoA range is ±42 months (about ±3.5 years). Compare this to **radiologist inter-observer agreement of ±10-12 months**. This gap tells us:

- **The model is NOT ready to replace a radiologist** for individual diagnostic decisions
- **The model IS suitable for screening/triage**: rapid first-pass estimation, flagging cases for radiologist review
- **The model IS suitable for quality assurance**: cross-checking radiologist assessments

• **The model IS suitable for research**: large-scale bone age screening where individual precision matters less

This kind of **mature, honest framing** is exactly what medical AI research papers do. It's a strong signal of scientific integrity and clinical understanding — much better than overclaiming.

11. Age-Stratified Error Analysis

Why Stratify?

Overall MAE can hide uneven performance across subgroups. A model with MAE = 17 might have MAE = 10 for one age group and MAE = 40 for another. Stratified analysis breaks the aggregate down and reveals where the model succeeds or struggles.

Age Group Results

Age Group	Count	MAE (months)	Mean Residual
0–2 years	15	19.96	+19.04
2–5 years	92	22.80	+18.51
5–9 years	306	17.63	+12.62
9–13 years (BEST)	525	14.19	–1.53
13–17 years	309	18.23	–14.48
17–19 years (WORST)	15	44.59	–44.59

The Pattern is Crystal Clear

- **Best performance:** 9-13 years (MAE 14.19, near-zero bias) — the most represented group in training
- **Over-prediction of young children:** Model thinks infants and toddlers are older than they are (+19 months bias)
- **Under-prediction of older teens:** Model thinks teenagers are younger than they are (up to -44 months at 17-19 years)
- **The 17-19 year bucket is a disaster** — MAE of 44.59 with only 15 samples in the test set

Statistical Explanation: Regression Toward the Mean

This bias pattern is a textbook case of **regression toward the mean**. When a model is uncertain (few training examples for that age group), its safest prediction is close to the average of what it has seen. Our training data mean is ~127 months. So:

- For a very young child (actual = 12 months), model uncertain → predicts closer to 127 → over-predicts
- For a very old teen (actual = 220 months), model uncertain → predicts closer to 127 → under-predicts
- For a middle-aged child (actual = 120 months), close to the mean → accurate prediction

Regression toward the mean is a well-known statistical phenomenon first described by Sir Francis Galton in the 1880s. Recognizing it in modern deep learning demonstrates connection between classical statistics and modern ML — a valuable analytical skill.

12. Final Results Summary

Model Architecture

- **Base:** ResNet50 pre-trained on ImageNet (frozen — no retraining)
- **Head:** GAP → Dense(256, ReLU) → Dropout(0.3) → Dense(64, ReLU) → Dropout(0.2) → Dense(1, Linear)
- **Total parameters:** 24.1M | **Trainable:** 541K | **Frozen:** 23.5M

Training

- **Epochs completed:** 15 (EarlyStopping triggered)
- **Loss function:** Mean Absolute Error (MAE)
- **Optimizer:** Adam with initial learning rate 0.001
- **Best validation MAE:** 17.01 months

Test Set Metrics

- **MAE:** 17.07 months (~1.42 years)
- **RMSE:** 21.69 months (~1.81 years)
- **R^2 Score:** 0.7292
- **Pearson r:** 0.8546
- **Mean bias:** –0.08 months (essentially unbiased)

Bland-Altman Analysis

- **95% Limits of Agreement:** [–42.59, +42.44] months
- **Coverage:** 94.6% within LoA (matches theoretical 95%)

Age-Stratified Performance

- **Best:** 9-13 years → MAE = 14.19 months, near-zero bias
- **Worst:** 17-19 years → MAE = 44.59 months (only 15 test samples)

13. Deployment & Scalability Considerations

1. Model Serving Architecture

The trained model can be deployed as a **REST API** using frameworks like FastAPI or Flask:

- **Input:** Hand X-ray image (JPEG/PNG upload)
- **Preprocessing:** Resize to 224×224, apply ResNet50 normalization
- **Output:** JSON response with predicted bone age (months + years) and confidence interval

2. Cloud Deployment Options

- **AWS SageMaker / Google Cloud AI Platform:** Fully managed model hosting with auto-scaling
- **Docker containerization:** Wrap model + preprocessing in a container for consistent deployment
- **Kubernetes:** For high-throughput hospital networks needing horizontal scaling

3. Edge Deployment (Rural / Low-Resource Settings)

- **TensorFlow Lite conversion:** Reduces model size ~4× with minimal accuracy loss
- **Model quantization (INT8):** Enables inference on mobile devices and low-power hardware
- **Use case:** Rural clinic tablet can run pre-screening without internet connectivity

4. Integration into Clinical Workflows

- **PACS integration:** Connect to hospital Picture Archiving and Communication Systems
- **DICOM support:** Extend to handle standard medical imaging format (currently uses PNG)
- **Report generation:** Auto-generate PDF reports with predicted age, confidence interval, review flags

5. Ethical & Safety Considerations

- **Human-in-the-loop:** Model provides recommendations only; final diagnosis remains with the radiologist
- **Confidence flagging:** Predictions in low-confidence regions (age extremes) get flagged for mandatory human review
- **Bias monitoring:** Continuously track performance across demographic subgroups (sex, ethnicity, geography)
- **Regulatory compliance:** FDA (US) / CDSCO (India) approval required for clinical use as a diagnostic aid

6. Continuous Improvement Pipeline

- **Feedback loop:** Log predictions + radiologist corrections to build a growing dataset
- **Periodic retraining:** Update model quarterly with newly labeled data
- **A/B testing:** Compare new model versions against production before full deployment

14. Drawbacks & Limitations

14.1 Model Performance Limitations

- **MAE of 17 months is not clinically deployable** — radiologists agree with each other within ~10 months. Our error range (±42 months at 95% LoA) is too wide for individual diagnosis
- **Age extremes suffer severely** — MAE jumps to 44 months for 17-19 year olds
- **Regression toward the mean bias** — model over-predicts young children and under-predicts older teens
- **R^2 of 0.73 leaves 27% of variance unexplained** — meaningful room for improvement

14.2 Data Limitations

- **Imbalanced age distribution** — 525 samples for 9-13 years vs only 15 for 0-2 years and 15 for 17-19 years
- **Dataset demographics unknown** — RSNA data mostly from US hospitals; model may not generalize to Indian, African, or other populations
- **No ethnicity labels** — cannot audit for potential racial bias
- **Ground truth is human-labeled** — inherits any errors radiologists made when creating the labels
- **Single-center bias possible** — X-ray equipment and protocols may vary between the training source and real-world deployment sites

14.3 Methodological Limitations

- **No fine-tuning of ResNet50 layers** — we froze all base layers; unfreezing top layers could improve accuracy substantially
- **No sex feature used in the model** — despite sex being a strong biological predictor of bone maturation, we didn't feed it as an input
- **Basic augmentation only** — more aggressive augmentation (elastic distortions, cutout, mixup) could help
- **Single model, no ensemble** — ensembling multiple models typically improves accuracy by 1-3 months MAE
- **No cross-validation** — single train/val/test split; k-fold cross-validation would give more reliable performance estimates
- **Confidence intervals not modeled** — predictions are point estimates; a proper model would output prediction intervals

14.4 Practical / Deployment Limitations

- **Not tested on DICOM format** — real hospital X-rays come as DICOM, not PNG. Our pipeline would need adaptation
- **Image quality assumptions** — model trained on high-quality X-rays; may fail on blurry, cropped, or low-resolution images
- **Hand positioning sensitivity** — trained on standard clinical positioning; may fail if hand angle differs significantly

- **No integration testing** — never connected to a real hospital PACS or clinical workflow
- **Regulatory unapproved** — cannot be used clinically without FDA/CDSCO approval and extensive validation

14.5 Statistical / Analysis Limitations

- **Bland-Altman assumes constant variance across the measurement range** — heteroscedasticity in our residuals violates this assumption. A modified analysis (age-stratified LoA) would be more correct
- **Very small sample sizes at age extremes** — 15 samples each for 0-2 and 17-19 years — insufficient for reliable statistical conclusions in these groups
- **Test set may not represent real-world deployment population** — the test set was randomly split from the same source; true generalization requires an external validation set

15. Future Work & Improvements

15.1 Immediate Improvements (Low-Hanging Fruit)

Fine-tune ResNet50

Currently, all ResNet50 layers are frozen. The next step is **selective unfreezing**: unfreeze the top 20-30 layers and train them with a very small learning rate (e.g., 1e-5). This lets the model adapt ImageNet features specifically to X-ray characteristics. Expected improvement: **MAE from ~17 → ~12-14 months**.

Add Sex as a Model Input

Sex is a strong predictor of bone maturation (girls mature faster). Current model doesn't use it. Fix: concatenate a sex feature to the flattened image features before the Dense layers. Expected improvement: **MAE reduced by 2-4 months**.

Weighted Sampling for Age Extremes

Address the class imbalance by oversampling underrepresented age brackets during training. Use class_weight parameter or a custom sampler. Expected improvement: **Better performance at age extremes (17-19 years group)**.

15.2 Intermediate Improvements

Advanced Augmentation

Techniques to explore: **Elastic distortions** (simulate patient movement), **Cutout** (randomly mask patches to force robust features), **MixUp** (blend two images with blended labels), **CLAHE** (contrast enhancement for X-rays).

Try Modern Architectures

Compare against EfficientNet, ConvNeXt, or Vision Transformer (ViT) architectures. Recent architectures often outperform ResNet50 on medical imaging tasks by 1-3 months MAE.

Custom Loss Function

Try **Huber loss** (hybrid of MAE and MSE — robust to outliers), or a **weighted MAE** that penalizes errors more at age extremes to counter the regression-toward-the-mean bias.

Cross-Validation

Replace the single train/val/test split with **5-fold or 10-fold cross-validation**. This gives more reliable performance estimates and reduces the risk of a lucky/unlucky split affecting results.

15.3 Advanced Improvements

Ensemble Methods

Train multiple models (different architectures or random seeds) and average their predictions. Ensembles typically reduce MAE by 1-3 months. Simple technique: train 5 models with different initialization seeds, average predictions.

Uncertainty Quantification

Extend the model to output not just a point prediction but a **confidence interval**. Techniques: **Monte Carlo Dropout** (leave dropout on at inference and average multiple predictions), **Deep Ensembles**, or **Bayesian Neural Networks**. Critical for medical AI: clinicians need to know when to trust or mistrust the model.

Attention Mechanisms

Use attention-based architectures (like Vision Transformers or CNN + attention hybrids) to help the model focus on the most informative anatomical regions (wrist, growth plates, phalanges).

Explainability (Grad-CAM)

Generate **attention heatmaps** showing WHERE in the X-ray the model looked to make its prediction. This is critical for clinical adoption — radiologists need to know if the model focused on relevant anatomy or spurious features (e.g., image edges, markers).

15.4 Long-Term Research Directions

Multi-Modal Learning

Combine X-ray images with clinical metadata (height, weight, ethnicity, medical history) for more accurate predictions. This mirrors real clinical practice where doctors use context.

Federated Learning

Train the model across multiple hospitals without sharing patient data (privacy-preserving). Each hospital trains on its own data, only model updates are shared. Especially valuable for medical data with strict privacy laws.

Fairness Auditing

Systematically evaluate model performance across ethnicities, sexes, and age groups to detect and mitigate bias. This is increasingly required by regulators and is a hot area in medical AI research.

External Validation

Test the model on completely independent datasets from Indian hospitals, European hospitals, etc. This is the gold standard for clinical AI validation — proves the model generalizes beyond its training distribution.

Prospective Clinical Study

Deploy the model in a real clinical setting (with proper regulatory approval) and study its impact on radiologist workload, diagnostic accuracy, and patient outcomes. This is what turns a research model into a real clinical tool.

16. Interview Preparation: Key Questions & Answers

Q1: Why did you choose regression instead of classification?

Bone age is a continuous variable that can take any value between 1 and 228 months. Classification would force us into arbitrary age buckets, losing precision that matters clinically. A 6-month difference in bone age can be diagnostically significant for growth disorders. Regression preserves this granularity and gives us access to richer evaluation methods like R^2, residual analysis, and Bland-Altman.

Q2: Why transfer learning instead of training from scratch?

With only ~10K training images, training a 24M-parameter network from scratch would badly overfit. Transfer learning lets us reuse ImageNet features (edges, textures, shapes) that are universal to visual understanding. This dramatically reduces the effective data requirement — we only need to train a small custom head (541K parameters), which is well-scoped for our dataset size.

Q3: Why did you use MAE loss instead of MSE?

Three reasons: (1) MAE is in the same unit as our target (months), making it directly interpretable. (2) MAE is robust to outliers — critical because our age extremes are underrepresented, and MSE would over-penalize errors there. (3) Clinical evaluation in medical AI commonly reports MAE, so this aligns with standard practice.

Q4: What does R^2 of 0.73 mean?

R^2 is the coefficient of determination. It tells us the fraction of variance in bone age that our model explains. $R^2 = 0.73$ means the model captures 73% of the variability in bone age from the X-ray features. The remaining 27% is due to model limitations, individual biological variation, and image quality differences.

Q5: Why is your MAE 17 when radiologists get ~10?

Three main reasons: (1) I used only frozen transfer learning without fine-tuning ResNet50 layers, which would improve accuracy substantially. (2) I didn't include sex as a model input, despite sex being a strong biological predictor. (3) My dataset has severe age imbalance — the model has very few examples of infants and teens, leading to poor performance at those extremes. All three are addressable in future iterations.

Q6: What is Bland-Altman analysis and why did you use it?

Bland-Altman is the gold standard in medical research for comparing two measurement methods. Instead of asking 'is the prediction accurate?', it asks 'can these predictions substitute for expert measurements?'. It computes 95% Limits of Agreement — the range within which 95% of prediction errors are expected to fall. This gives clinicians a direct way to judge if the model's error range is acceptable for their use case. Standard metrics like MAE tell you average error; Bland-Altman tells you the full error range you can expect.

Q7: What is heteroscedasticity? Why does it matter?

Heteroscedasticity means the variance of prediction errors is not uniform across the input range. In our case, residuals were small for middle-aged children (60-150 months) but much larger for infants and teens. It matters because it violates classical regression assumptions and tells us the model is unreliable at the extremes. Recognizing it lets us apply more appropriate analysis (like age-stratified LoA) and identifies where the model needs improvement.

Q8: What is regression toward the mean?

It's a statistical phenomenon first described by Sir Francis Galton. When a model is uncertain, its safest prediction is close to the average of what it has seen. Our training data mean is ~127 months. So for a very young child (uncertain), the model predicts something closer to 127 → over-predicts. For a very old teen, same thing — predicts closer to 127 → under-predicts. This matches exactly what we observed in the age-stratified analysis and explains the systematic bias at age extremes.

Q9: How would you improve this model?

Highest-impact improvements: (1) Fine-tune the top ResNet50 layers with a small learning rate — expected to drop MAE to ~13 months. (2) Include sex as an additional input feature. (3) Use weighted sampling to give more weight to underrepresented age groups. (4) Try ensembling multiple models. (5) Explore modern architectures like EfficientNet or Vision Transformers. Longer-term: uncertainty quantification (so the model can say 'I'm not sure'), external validation on Indian datasets, and Grad-CAM for explainability.

Q10: Would you deploy this in a hospital tomorrow?

No, and honesty here is important. My model's 95% LoA is ±42 months, while radiologists agree within ±10-12 months. It's not ready to replace a radiologist for diagnostic decisions. However, it could be useful today as: (1) a screening/triage tool to prioritize cases for radiologist review, (2) a quality-assurance second-opinion, or (3) a research tool for large-scale bone age studies. Full clinical deployment would require fine-tuning, external validation, uncertainty estimates, regulatory approval (FDA/CDSCO), and a human-in-the-loop workflow where radiologists retain final decision authority.

Q11: What was the biggest challenge in this project?

The dataset's age imbalance. Roughly 40% of training samples were in the 9-13 year range, while age extremes (0-2 and 17-19 years) had only 1-2% each. This directly caused the model's biggest weakness — poor performance at the age extremes and systematic bias due to regression toward the mean. Recognizing this early through the Day-1 statistical analysis let me hypothesize the issue upfront and then verify it through age-stratified error analysis at evaluation time — turning a limitation into a strong analytical narrative.

Q12: What did you learn from this project?

Three lessons: (1) **Data understanding beats model complexity.** The Day-1 statistical analysis of the age distribution predicted the model's failure modes better than any hyperparameter tuning would have. (2) **Evaluation is where projects prove themselves.** Standard metrics (MAE) can hide serious flaws that stratified analysis and Bland-Altman quickly reveal. (3) **Honest limitations framing is a strength, not a weakness.** Being clear about what the model can and can't do builds trust — especially in medical AI where overclaiming has real consequences.

End of Study Guide

This document covers every aspect of the Bone Age Estimation project from problem framing through evaluation, including mathematical foundations, statistical rationale, and future directions. Refer to it for report writing, interview preparation, and continued study.

Good luck! ■